

THE CLAVE ACROSS GENRES

The clave is hidden in the stops of melodies across rock, funk, pop, soul, metal, and jazz

THE HIDDEN CLAVE

"Nobody plays the clave rhythm in 'Shape of You' — yet it's there."

The clave can be **HIDDEN** in the stops and starting points of melodies — not played explicitly as a percussion instrument.

You don't hear the clave itself. You **feel its pulse**. The stops of the vocal melody, guitar riff, or bass line cluster around the clave positions.

HOW TO FIND THE CLAVE IN ANY SONG — 3 STEPS

1

Find the Stops

Transcribe the melody (or the most prominent instrument) in the binary grid. Mark all stops — the last note before silence in each phrase.

2

Note the Positions

Record which of the 16 positions those stops fall on. Ignore non-stop notes — only the landing positions matter.

3

Match to the Clave Grid

Compare your stop positions against the 2-3 and 3-2 clave patterns. In a well-written song, most stops will align with clave positions.

THE CLAVE IN 6 GENRES

ROCK

"Every Teardrop is a Waterfall"

Coldplay

3-2 clave in vocal melody and guitar. The chorus vocal stops land precisely on the 3-side positions. Guitar riff fills the 2-side.

✓ 3-2 Clave

FUNK

"Get Up (I Feel Like Being a) Sex Machine"

James Brown

2-3 clave in guitar part. Vocal entrance on the 3-side confirms orientation. The guitar stop pattern is almost an exact 2-3 clave map.

✓ 2-3 Clave

POP

"Happy"

Pharrell Williams

2-3 clave. Analysis shows 13 out of 16 stops in the verse/chorus fall on strong Rhythm Code positions. Remarkably clean clave alignment.

✓ 2-3 Clave

SOUL / R&B

"Single Ladies (Put a Ring on It)"

Beyoncé

2-3 clave in kick + snare pattern. Vocal stops confirm orientation. The horn stabs also align with the 2-3 clave positions throughout.

✓ 2-3 Clave

METAL

"Shoot to Thrill"

AC/DC

3-2 clave in guitar stop pattern. Only one note in the main riff sits outside the clave grid. The 3-2 orientation matches the downbeat-heavy rock feel.

✓ 3-2 Clave

JAZZ / FUSION

"Corner of the Earth"

Jamiroquai

2-3 clave in vocal melody. The verse stop pattern maps cleanly to the 2-3 clave. Jay Kay's vocal phrasing implicitly follows clave structure throughout.

✓ 2-3 Clave

STARTING POINTS MATTER TOO

The **FIRST NOTE** of a motif often lands on a clave position, not just the stops.

"22" (Taylor Swift) — first note of the chorus lands on a clave position.

"Get Up" (James Brown) — the vocal starts precisely on a clave position and announces the orientation.

Rule: Both stops AND starting points of phrases cluster around clave positions in well-constructed songs. Stops = where phrases land. Starting points = where new phrases launch from.